



BOWLING MACHINE

- * Mohammed Siraj bowled 1,113 deliveries in the series — the only bowler besides Chris Woakes to cross 1,000 balls.
- * He played all five Tests in the series.
- * Siraj finished as the highest wicket-taker with 23 wickets.
- * His strike rate was 48.3 balls per dismissal.
- * This is the best bowling strike rate by an Indian pacer in an away Test series (minimum 1,000 balls bowled).



Leading from the front: Mohammed Siraj stepped up in Jasprit Bumrah's absence, picking 16 wickets at 19.81 in the two Tests that the latter missed.

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affords chances to make amends. Siraj gobbled that opportunity.

He induced so many false shots, 18 off 25 deliveries, on the final day that Indian fans wished for a provision that would allow him to steam in from both ends. Jamie Smith and Jamie Overton fell to his unerring ability to generate movement from a good length before he dug deep into his reserves of fortitude to produce that series-levelling low full toss to castle Atkinson.

If elite athletes swear by the adage 'mind over body', it is a curious case of 'body over mind' for Siraj. His bowling has an instinctive feel, and his ability to metronomically hit the good length is as though the routine is steeped in

his muscle memory. As many as 16 of his 23 scalps and 251 of the 283 false shots he has induced in this series were the result of homing in around that good length or just short of it.

Siraj seldom strayed full, delivering the second-lowest percentage (11.95) of full-length balls in the series, and second only to Bumrah (11 per cent), who played two matches less and bowled almost 400 balls fewer. Moreover, the eight yorkers he dished out in the whole series yielded four wickets. In the face of a heavy bowling load, Siraj's skills and clarity of thought have remained sharp. He is as much a battering ram as he is a precision strike weapon in India's arsenal, capable of delivering a scene-shifting payload when the pressure mounts.

He plies his trade across formats. In the last four years, Siraj has played 43 One-Day Internationals, while no other full-time Indian pacer has even touched 30 matches in the

corresponding period. His workload during this phase also includes 35 Tests, the most by an Indian. In the Indian Premier League, he was a vital cog of Royal Challengers Bengaluru's pace attack from 2021 to 2024, spearheads the battery at Gujarat Titans now, and is increasingly in the frame in India's T20I plans.

Still, the workload management strictures almost always skip Siraj, as though he is rendered invisible by his omnipresence. There are no calls to 'wrap him in cotton wool'. One must jog the memory to remember when he could afford to rest. With Bumrah's fitness a constant worry, he is still, at best, a stop-gap spearhead.

But all of that could, and should, change after the jamboree at The Oval. If his heroics against Australia at The Gabba in 2021 were the face of an emerging Indian pace powerhouse, Oval 2025 was emblematic of that talent announcing itself as a leader unto himself.